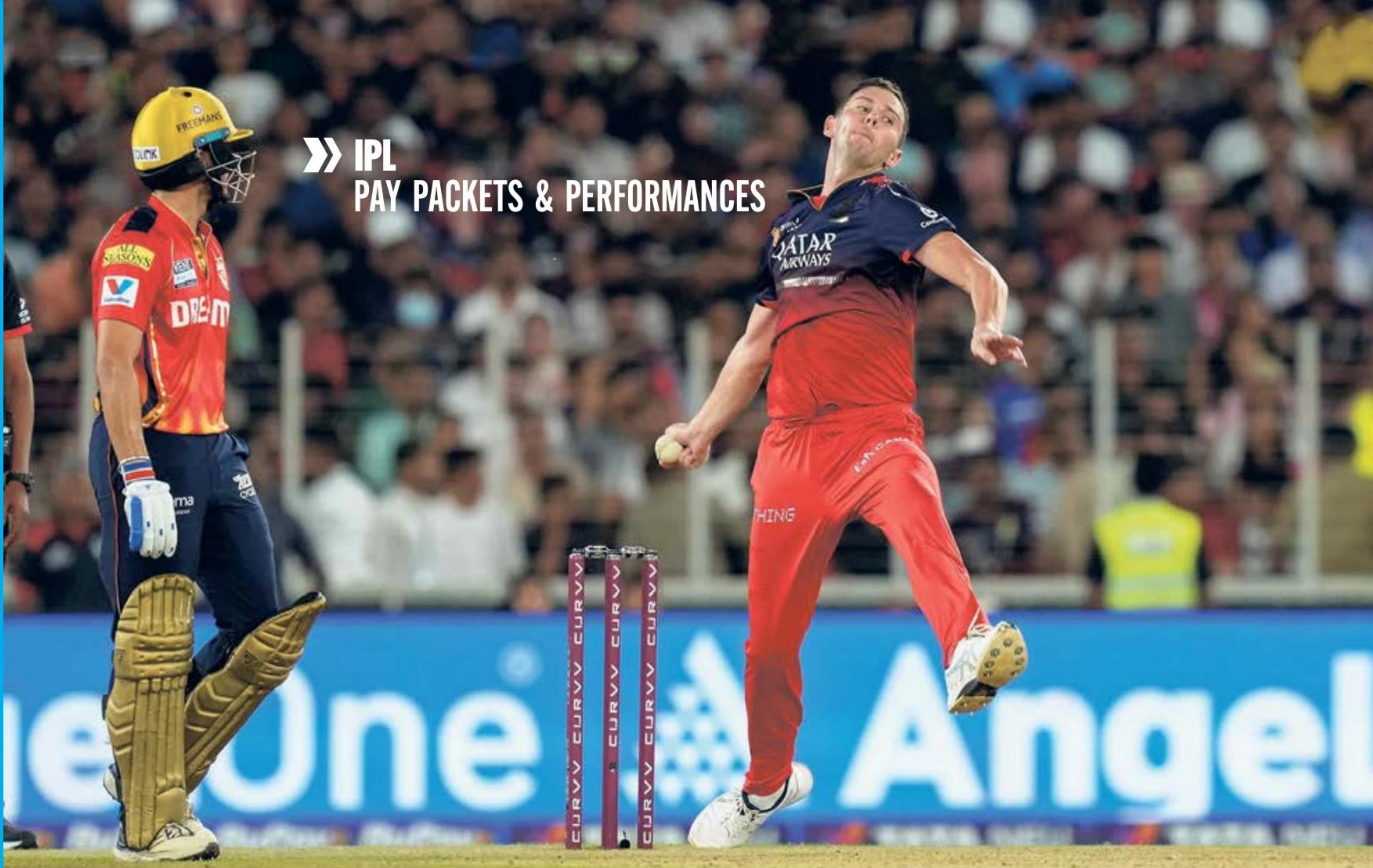


» IPL PAY PACKETS & PERFORMANCES



Standing tall: Josh Hazlewood wrapped up his season with 22 wickets in just 12 innings, striking first in the final by removing Priyansh Arya. PTI

FROM AUCTIONS TO IMPACT: THE TRUE MVPS OF IPL 2025

This year's IPL proved that **smart scouting and homegrown depth** now matter more than marquee names in the race for the title.

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An IPL season that follows a mega auction rarely plays out as predicted. With reshaped squads, fresh coaching combinations, and the unpredictability of form and fitness, every franchise starts with more questions than answers. The 2025 edition — the league's 18th — was no different.

It ended with a new champion for the first time since 2022.

RCB's red-letter day

Royal Challengers Bengaluru clinched its maiden IPL title, winning

a thrilling final against Punjab Kings by six runs in Ahmedabad on June 3. It was RCB's first appearance in a final since 2016, and it sealed the deal thanks to a well-rounded squad built through a sharp auction strategy — a distinct shift from its traditionally batting-heavy line-ups.

Led by Rajat Patidar, the team finally found the bowling depth it long lacked. RCB's biggest buy was Josh Hazlewood, acquired for Rs 12.5 crore. The Australian quick justified every rupee, taking 22 wickets at an economy of 8.77 and a strike rate of 12. His total bowling impact (+49.2) was the fourth-highest in the league.

Phil Salt, another marquee signing

at Rs 11.5 crore, won his second consecutive IPL title after scoring 403 runs at a strike rate of 175.98. The English opener's explosive starts in the PowerPlay set the tone for RCB's innings. His batting impact score of +90.6 ranked 10th in the league.

High price, low returns

It was a mixed bag for some of the auction's top earners.

Rishabh Pant, the most expensive player in IPL history (Rs 27 crore to LSG), struggled throughout. He scored 269 runs in 14 games at an average of 24.45 — his worst season since debuting in 2016. His batting impact was a dismal -18.8, with 118 of his runs coming in a single match